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AI BUSINESS ASSESSMENT BUSINESS PLAN

99 Out of 100 Small Businesses Need This Service · $1,000 per Audit · Claude Builds the Report · Voice Agent Runs the Interview · $3,000–$10,000 Upsell Menu · 7 Ways to Find Clients With Zero Following

Based on an exclusive interview with Corey Ganim
Founder of Return My Time | AI Assessment Agency | Build With AI Podcast | audittemplate.ai

The Koerner Office Podcast

The Business That Started With a Lunch Conversation

Corey Ganim was having lunch with a friend — a successful business owner — who said something that became the entire business: 'I would literally pay you $1,000 just to follow me around for a day in my office and tell me where I can be using AI.'

Corey drove home unable to shake the thought. If one successful person would pay $1,000 for an AI expert to look at his business, there must be others. He had talked to 50 to 100 business owners since and found the same thing every time: 99 out of 100 need the service. The AI adoption gap between what is possible and what most small businesses are actually doing is enormous, and almost every business owner feels it.

The business Corey built around that lunch conversation: the AI Business Assessment. A structured process where he learns what a business owner does, where their time goes, and what their biggest headaches are — then delivers a professional report with specific AI tools and software that solve those pain points, followed by a menu of higher-value implementation services. Starting price: $1,000. Upsells: $1,500 to $10,000 each. Delivery time: 48 hours.

The key insight: you do not need to be an AI expert to sell this. You just need to be one step ahead of the average client. Seven days of studying AI tools is enough to start. This document is the complete blueprint — how the assessment works, what the report looks like, how to find clients, and how to build the upsell business that turns $1,000 audits into $5,000–$20,000 client relationships.

$11B	26%	72%	99/100	$1,000
AI consulting market 2025 (→$117B by 2035)	Annual market growth rate (CAGR)	Companies now using AI in some function	Business owners who need this service	Entry price for the AI Assessment

> *"99 out of a hundred people need the service. That's a three to $5,000 upsell all day. You don't need to be an AI expert. You just need to be one step ahead of your average client, which is literally you studying this stuff for 7 days." — Corey Ganim*

PART 01

The Market: Why AI Consulting for Small Business Is the Opportunity of 2026

AI adoption is doubling. 72% of companies use AI. Most small businesses don't know where to start. You bridge the gap.

Opportunity: AI consulting market: $11B → $117B by 2035 at 26% CAGR. SMBs are the fastest-growing segment.

The Size and Scale of the Opportunity

AI Consulting Services Market Growth (Billions USD)

2024	$16.4B global market
2025	$22.3B projected
2026	$28.2B — doubling every ~3 years
2028	$45B+ on current trajectory
2035	$117B by 2035 (26% CAGR)

The Gap That Makes This Business Possible

The AI consulting market is dominated by large firms serving enterprise clients. The small business segment — companies with 5 to 50 employees — is almost entirely underserved. The reasons:

- Enterprise firms charge $200–$500/hour for AI consulting; small businesses cannot afford that
- Large firms focus on complex, multi-month engagements; small businesses need quick wins
- 72% of companies now use AI in at least one function — but most small businesses do not know how to start
- 50% of businesses are projected to adopt AI-driven cognitive technologies by 2026 (Gartner) — creating massive demand for accessible guidance
- The AI skills gap is cited as the #1 barrier to AI adoption — small businesses need someone who already knows which tools to use

Corey's insight: the small business owner is overwhelmed and does not know what they do not know. They are not looking for a machine learning engineer. They are looking for someone who

can look at their specific business and say: 'Here is where you are leaving hours and money on the table, and here is the specific tool that fixes it.'

Why Right Now Is the Best Time to Enter This Market

Several forces have aligned in 2026 to create an ideal moment for AI assessment services:

- AI tools have proliferated to the point where there are thousands of off-the-shelf solutions for every business problem — but business owners cannot evaluate them
- Companies expect to double AI spending in 2026 (BCG AI Radar 2026) — budgets exist; willingness to spend exists
- Worker access to AI rose 50% in 2025 (Deloitte) — business owners are hearing about AI constantly and want help applying it
- The tools that make delivering this service possible — Claude, voice AI platforms, Gamma for report design — are now accessible to non-technical operators
- Competition in the small business segment is minimal; most AI consultants are chasing enterprise clients

PART 02

How the AI Assessment Works: The Full Process End to End

From $0 to $200 to $500 to $1,000. Voice agent → transcript → Claude → Gamma report → follow-up call → upsell.

Opportunity: One assessment = $1,000. 48-hour turnaround. Near 100% profit margin on the assessment itself.

The Three Iterations: How Corey Found the Right Model

Corey's assessment business evolved through three iterations, each solving the main bottleneck of the previous one:

Iteration	Format	Bottleneck	Why It Was Abandoned
Version 1	Follow the owner around their office for a day	Cannot physically be in multiple offices simultaneously; not scalable	Too capital-intensive in time; only one client per day

Version 2 (Loom)	Owner records their own screen during a work session; Corey reviews the recording	Too much friction for the client; most had never used Loom; required interrupting their work	Adoption too low; clients uncomfortable; too many variables
Version 3 (Zoom)	45-minute Zoom call with the owner; Corey conducts the interview manually	Only so many Zoom calls possible in a day; still Corey's time	Bottleneck shifted from client's friction to Corey's time
Version 4 (Current)	Voice agent 'Annie' calls the business owner; 20–30 minute AI phone interview; transcript auto-feeds to report agent	Essentially none — runs 24/7 without Corey's involvement	This is the current model

The Current Model: Annie the Voice Agent

The current version of the assessment is fully automated at the data-gathering stage. Here is how it works:

1. Corey (or whoever sold the assessment) shares a phone number with the business owner.
2. The owner calls the number at any time, day or night. 'Annie' — an AI voice agent built on Retell.ai — answers immediately.
3. Annie introduces herself: 'Hi there, I'm Annie from Return My Time. Thanks for hopping on. This is a quick chat to learn about your business and what your day-to-day looks like so I can spot the best places AI can give you time back. You ready to get started?'
4. Annie asks the owner their name, what their business does, how long they have been running it, how many people are on their team, what tools and software they use, and then — the most important question — 'What's the biggest headache in your workday right now?'
5. The conversation lasts 20–30 minutes. Annie starts with general questions and moves toward industry-specific ones based on the owner's answers. Corey has built a master question bank from eight or nine different industries, and Annie draws from the relevant questions for each business type.
6. Annie does not prescribe any solutions or tools on the call. Her only job is to gather information and identify pain points.
7. When the call ends, the transcript is automatically piped to a separate AI agent that analyzes the conversation and builds the assessment report.

> On Camera Demo: Kerner called Annie live during the interview. She greeted him, asked what he does (e-commerce on Amazon), how long he had been doing it (9 years), whether he ran it solo or had a team (2 warehouse employees, 4 VAs), what tools he used (Google Workspace, Smart Scout), and what his biggest bottleneck was (finding new suppliers). The interaction was smooth, natural, and indistinguishable from a human interviewer. Corey's assessment: 'I feel like I'm talking to a human.' She would have continued for another 10–15 minutes identifying more pain points.

Building the Report: Claude + Gamma

After the transcript is generated, the report-building process is automated in two steps:

Step 1: Processing the Transcript

A series of AI agent 'skills' (Corey's term for specialized sub-agents, each with one task) processes the raw transcript:

- Skill 1: Clean and format the raw transcript
- Skill 2: Identify and categorize the pain points mentioned by the owner
- Skill 3: Research AI and software tools from directories like Futurepedia and There's An AI For That (.com) to find specific tools that address each pain point
- Skill 4: Map each pain point on an effort vs. impact matrix to prioritize recommendations
- Skill 5: Calculate the financial impact of recommended changes (hours saved x hourly rate)
- Output: a structured .docx file containing all assessment content, ready to be formatted

For someone starting out: you do not need this multi-agent architecture. You can take the voice call transcript, paste it into Claude, and say: 'I attached the transcript of a conversation with a local business owner. Your job is to find AI tools or software tools they can implement that are off-the-shelf and can fix the pain points you identified from the transcript.' Claude will do this reliably. Then ask it to explain how to implement each tool.

Step 2: Report Formatting in Gamma

Once the .docx output is ready, it is uploaded to Gamma (gamma.app) — an AI-powered slide and document creation platform. Gamma uses the uploaded content to auto-generate a

professionally designed visual report based on a template. Corey's free template is available at audittemplate.ai.

What the Report Looks Like: Section by Section

Section	Content	Purpose
Executive Summary	Reiterates the owner's key pain points; states the outcome they could receive (e.g., '8 hours per week reclaimed')	Validates that you listened; anchors the value proposition immediately
Effort vs. Impact Matrix	Every pain point mapped on a 2x2 grid: low effort vs high effort on one axis, low impact vs high impact on the other	Prioritizes 'quick wins' — low effort, high impact — so the owner knows exactly where to start
Recommended Solutions	For each quick-win pain point: the specific tool, what it does, why it fits this business, and the approximate cost	This is the meat of the report — the specific, researched, personalized recommendations
4-Day Quick Win Plan	Day-by-day action plan for implementing the recommendations, broken into manageable steps	Removes overwhelm; makes implementation feel achievable; increases client satisfaction
Upsell Opportunities Section	Identifies the larger, higher-effort changes that require implementation help — setting the stage for the follow-up call	Plants the seed for the upsell conversation; gives the owner a roadmap for what comes after quick wins
Financial Impact Quantification	Total hours saved per week x assumed hourly rate ($100) = annual value; minus monthly tool costs = net gain	Makes the ROI concrete and calculable; justifies the assessment fee and any implementation upsell

The Follow-Up Call: Where the Upsell Happens

After the report is delivered (within 48 hours), the client receives it to review in advance. Then Corey schedules a 30-minute follow-up call where he screen-shares the report and walks through it slide by slide. This call has two purposes: (1) ensure the client understands and values the recommendations, and (2) identify which upsell opportunity is the right next step.

Pricing evolution and the perception effect:

- Started: free (to get testimonials and work out the process)
- Phase 2: $200 (clients said 'great value!' but did not take upsells as seriously)

- Phase 3: $500 (improved; still felt like a 'cheap service' to some clients)
- Current: $1,000 (clients are more bought in; more attentive; more likely to pursue upsells)

The logic: a client who has invested $1,000 is primed to invest $3,500 more. The jump from $200 to $3,500 feels enormous. The jump from $1,000 to $3,500 feels reasonable. Charging more for the assessment is not just about the assessment — it is about setting the psychological anchor for everything that follows.

PART 03

The Upsell Menu: Where the Real Money Is

Four categories of upsells. $1,500 to $10,000+ each. One audit can unlock an ongoing client relationship.

Opportunity: A single $1,000 assessment can lead to $10,000–$20,000 in total client revenue.

The Four Upsell Categories

Corey has identified four main categories of implementation work that naturally emerge from the assessment. The key is to specialize in one upsell first — do not try to offer all four from day one.

Upsell Category	What It Is	Price Range	Example
1. Process Optimization	Fix a broken process before automating it. Many processes take 10 hours/week because they have 15 steps when 7 would do.	$3,000–$5,000 per engagement	A 15-step weekly reporting process is redesigned to 7 steps; saves 8 hours/week before any AI is added

2. Automation Builds (Zapier / Make)	Build the actual automation once the process is optimized. Simple 2-step zaps or complex multi-step workflows.	$1,000–$3,000 per build	Wedding venue: Zapier automation to format new client Asana projects → $1,500; saved operations manager 30 min per new client
3. Knowledge System (Custom GPT or AI Agent)	Train an AI agent on the client's specific documents, FAQs, or processes so it can handle common questions without the owner.	$2,000–$5,000 setup + recurring	Business brokerage: custom GPT trained on listing SIM to handle 95% of the 400 buyer emails per listing; owner only sees the 5%
4. Speed-to-Lead Agent	AI agent that responds to incoming website forms or leads within seconds, in a personalized way, and attempts to book a call.	$2,000–$5,000 setup	Wedding venue: AI agent trained on FAQs and property info; answers leads while sales rep is on tours; immediately increased tour bookings

Deep Dive: The Wedding Venue Case Study

The single client Corey referenced most in the interview illustrates how the full model works — assessment through upsell:

- Assessment discovery: operations manager spends 2 hours every Saturday manually compiling marketing analytics from Google Analytics, Meta Ads, and Google Ads into a spreadsheet, then converting it to a PowerPoint for the board
- Quick win recommendation: Dash This ($42/month) — connects to all analytics platforms and auto-generates a dashboard, eliminating the spreadsheet and PowerPoint steps
- Impact: 8 hours/month saved; $42/month cost; net value at $100/hour = $800/month in recaptured time; clear ROI
- Upsell 1 (Automation, $1,500): Zapier automation to format new client Asana projects automatically; saved 30 minutes per new client onboarded
- Upsell 2 (Speed-to-Lead, ~$2,500–$5,000): AI agent trained on the venue's FAQs to respond to website leads while the sales rep is giving in-person tours. Average deal size: $11,000. Close rate from tours: 40%. One additional tour per month from faster lead response = $4,400 additional monthly revenue. If the agent gets 2 extra tours/month = $8,800/month from a one-time implementation cost.

Total client revenue from one assessment: $1,000 (assessment) + $1,500 (Zapier build) + ~$3,500 (speed-to-lead agent) = $6,000 from one client, with ongoing potential for additional engagements as the business evolves.

The Business Brokerage Case Study: The Knowledge System

A business brokerage owner (Ron) handles 5–7 listings per year, each attracting 200–400 emails in the first week — 95% of which are the same 10 questions:

- Problem: Ron, the owner, is personally answering hundreds of emails about each listing — not the best use of his time for a deal that closes at $500,000+
- Solution: a custom GPT trained on the SIM (Selling/Information Memorandum — the marketing package for the listing)
- Implementation: the custom GPT answers any question a buyer has about the listing; only the 5% of questions it cannot answer reach Ron's inbox
- Economics: once the system prompt template is built, Ron can deploy it for every new listing; the incremental cost is minimal
- Recurring revenue: charge setup fee for initial build + monthly maintenance/update fee per listing; every new listing is a repeat sale

Upsell Specialization Strategy

Corey's key advice: do not try to upsell everything from the beginning. Pick one upsell and get very good at it:

- If you are just starting, the Speed-to-Lead agent is the most directly tied to revenue — it is easy to quantify, immediately impactful, and business owners understand it immediately
- The custom GPT / Knowledge System is the most repeatable — one template, deployed over and over for different clients and different listings/projects
- Automation builds (Zapier/Make) are the easiest to learn — even basic automation knowledge is worth $1,000–$3,000 per implementation
- Process optimization is the highest ticket but requires more consulting experience — save it for after you have done 10–15 assessments
- The financial anchor rule: find the upsell that is most directly tied to either revenue generation or cost savings. That is the easiest sell.

Case Studies: Real AI Assessment Businesses

Case Study 1: Corey Ganim — Return My Time (The Subject of This Episode)

Corey's trajectory from the lunch conversation to a fully automated AI assessment business:

Phase	Price Point	Key Development	Revenue Signal
Phase 1: Validation	Free	Did 2–3 free assessments for a CEO peer group; got testimonials; worked out the process	Proof of concept; testimonials secured
Phase 2: Early Pricing	$200	Market responded positively but clients were not deeply invested	Discovered the perceived value problem

Phase 3: Market Rate	$500	Better engagement; some upsells; still felt underpriced	Upsell conversations improved
Phase 4: Current	$1,000	Clients fully bought in; upsells flowing; voice agent handles all intake	Multiple $3–6K clients from single assessments
Future State	$1,000+ assessment; $3–10K upsells	Full agent automation; report delivered in 48 hrs; no Zoom for intake	Scalable; limited only by upsell delivery capacity

Case Study 2: The Barber School

One of the more unexpected clients Corey described was a barber school. This illustrates that the AI assessment model works across every industry:

- The owner of a barber school had never thought about AI as something relevant to their business
- The assessment revealed: student scheduling was done manually (automation opportunity), instructor feedback was given verbally with no record (documentation system opportunity), marketing content creation was entirely done by the owner manually (AI content generation opportunity)
- Three clear upsell pathways emerged from a business that most people would not associate with AI
- Key lesson: the assessment works everywhere. The less tech-forward the business, the more low-hanging fruit there is.

Case Study 3: The Realtor Office AI Workshop

Corey's first client acquisition story — how the local AI meetup concept actually played out:

- Corey contacted the realtor who sold him his house — a well-connected local professional
- He asked: 'Do you want to either partner on this free AI event or can I do it inside your office for your team?'
- She said yes immediately. He used her office, she provided the audience.
- Attendees: real estate brokers, agents, the broker-in-charge of the office
- Format: free 20–25 minute presentation; pure value; no pitch; emails collected at the door
- Result: assessment clients from the event; the broker-in-charge became a client

- Revenue from the event: multiple $1,000 assessments plus upsells that followed
- Cost of the event: essentially zero — no venue fee, no marketing spend, no ad budget

Case Study 4: The Mortgage Broker (The Lunch Friend)

The original client who inspired the business. A successful mortgage broker:

- Context: a super successful business owner who spent money freely on things that made his business better
- His exact words: 'I would literally pay you $1,000 just to follow me around for a day in my office and tell me where I can use AI'
- What he got instead: a structured 45-minute conversation, a professional report identifying where AI could save him time, and a follow-up call
- His reaction: 'Wow, I wish we would have known about these tools 6 months ago. What else can we do together?'
- Key insight from this case: the friend's willingness to pay $1,000 for an AI tour of his business was not unique to him. It was universal. Corey confirmed this by talking to 50–100 business owners.

Case Study 5: The Door-Knock Lead

One of Corey's seven client acquisition methods is door-knocking local businesses. This sounds counterintuitive — until you consider the context:

- In 2026, AI is the most talked-about topic in business. Every owner is wondering how it applies to them.
- Walking into a business and saying 'I help small businesses figure out where AI can save them time and money' is not a cold pitch — it is a conversation that the owner has been wanting to have
- The comparison: door-knocking for insurance or home services is hard because you are interrupting someone's day to sell them something they did not ask for. Door-knocking about AI is different — you are offering to answer a question they are already asking.
- Corey's approach: lead with value, never with a sales pitch. The conversation may naturally lead to an assessment inquiry. If it does not, you have still made a contact who knows a lot of other people.

- Starting price advantage: if you are charging $200–$500 for the assessment when starting out, the bar is even lower. 'I help businesses do a $200 AI audit' is one of the easiest conversations a door-knocker has ever had.

PART 05 7 Ways to Find Clients: The Full Customer Acquisition Playbook

The exact seven methods Corey published on X for finding AI consulting clients with zero following.

Opportunity: Method 1 alone (local AI meetup) generated multiple $1,000 assessment clients for Corey.

The Context

Corey published an article on X titled 'Seven Ways to Sell AI Services if Nobody Knows Who You Are.' These seven methods apply whether you have zero online following or a significant one. Most people will do none of them. That is the point — the bar for standing out is very low because almost no one is doing the obvious things.

Method	What You Do	Who Can Do It	Expected Outcome
1. Host a Local AI Meetup	Go on Luma or meetup.com and post 'AI for Small Business Meetup.' You are the organizer — that automatically makes you the authority. No sales pitch. Pure value. Collect emails at the door.	Anyone — zero audience required	Multiple assessment leads from attendees; broker-in-charge relationships; local business network expansion
2. Door-Knock Local Businesses	Walk into businesses you pass every day and start a conversation about AI. Lead with: 'I help small businesses figure out where AI can save them time.'	Anyone willing to have a conversation	Foot in the door with business owners who are already thinking about AI; low resistance because you are answering a question they have

3. Free Assessments for Your Network	Reach out to your existing CEO peer group, professional contacts, or local business owners and offer 1–2 free assessments to get testimonials and work out your process.	Anyone with a professional network	Testimonials; refined process; warm upsell opportunities with people who know and trust you
4. AI Office Hours	Offer to host free weekly or monthly AI office hours at a co-working space or a local professional office (realtor offices are perfect). You show up with your laptop and answer AI questions.	Anyone — no expertise required beyond being 7 days ahead of the average client	High-quality local contacts; assessment leads; workshop opportunities; referrals from brokers and office managers
5. LinkedIn Content	Post consistently about AI for small business. Document your learning. Share case studies (with permission). Offer free quick tips.	Anyone with a LinkedIn profile and willingness to post	Inbound inquiries; credibility building; referrals as your network grows
6. Referral Partnerships	Partner with professionals who serve your ideal client — accountants, bookkeepers, web designers, business coaches — and offer a referral fee for any client they send.	Anyone with professional contacts	Warm leads from trusted referrers; often the highest-converting source
7. DM Outreach on LinkedIn/X	Identify small business owners, send genuinely personalized messages about AI, offer a free 15-minute conversation about how AI could help their specific business.	Anyone — requires time but zero money	Direct client conversations; can be systematized once you find a message that works

Why This Works Even Without Expertise

The most common objection to starting this business: 'I'm not an AI expert.' Corey's response is definitive: you do not need to be. Here is why:

- Your average client is starting at zero. They are not using Fathom, Fireflies, DashThis, or any AI tools. They do not know what a custom GPT is. They have never heard of Zapier.

- You only need to be one step ahead — and one step ahead means: you have spent 7 days learning AI tools, you know how to prompt Claude effectively, and you have tested a few tools yourself
- The assessment process itself does not require expertise — it requires curiosity. Annie (or you, in early iterations) asks questions. Claude identifies tools. You deliver the report.
- The upsells require more knowledge — but you can start with the simplest upsell (the custom GPT or a basic Zapier automation) and build from there
- Corey's admission: when the report prescribes a tool he has never heard of, he asks Claude to explain it and how to implement it before the follow-up call. This is normal. The tool does the research.

5 Adjacent Business Opportunities

The AI assessment business builds infrastructure, client relationships, and market knowledge that opens five natural adjacent revenue streams.

Adjacent 1: AI Workshops and Training Programs for Professional Offices

The local AI meetup concept that Corey used for client acquisition can itself become a paid product:

- Charge $500–$2,500 for a half-day 'AI for Your Industry' workshop at a professional office (realtor office, law firm, accounting firm, dental practice)
- Content: what AI tools exist, which ones are most relevant to their role, hands-on demos, Q&A
- Client acquisition tool: every workshop generates 3–10 assessment leads from attendees who want personalized analysis of their specific workflow
- Scale: 2–4 workshops per month at $1,000 average = $2,000–$4,000/month from workshops alone, before any assessments or upsells
- Recurring: quarterly 'AI Update' workshops for the same offices as the AI landscape evolves — ongoing relationship revenue

Adjacent 2: AI Assessment Certification and Training for Other Consultants

Once you have delivered 20–30 assessments and built a repeatable process, you have something other aspiring AI consultants want to buy:

- Product: a course or certification teaching the AI assessment model — the process, the prompts, the questions, the Gamma template, the upsell menu, the client acquisition methods
- Price: $997–$2,997 for a comprehensive course; $4,997–$9,997 for a cohort with live coaching
- Corey's audittemplate.ai is already the beginning of this — a free template that serves as a top-of-funnel lead magnet for a paid program
- The market: thousands of people want to sell AI services; most do not know where to start; a proven blueprint with a track record is exactly what they need

Adjacent 3: AI Tool Implementation Agency (White-Label)

The logical extension of the assessment business is an implementation business — but not just for your own assessment clients. As you develop expertise in building Zapier automations, custom GPTs, Retell.ai voice agents, and CRM setups, you can white-label these services for other agencies:

- Model: web agencies, marketing agencies, and business coaches who have clients asking about AI outsource the implementation to you
- Pricing: $1,500–$5,000 per implementation, delivered under the referring agency's brand
- You are invisible to the end client; the agency earns the markup; you do the technical work
- Scale: 5 agency partners, each sending you 2 implementations per month = 10 builds/month at $2,500 average = $25,000/month

Adjacent 4: Retainer-Based AI Operations Partner

After completing an assessment and one or two implementations for a client, you have deep knowledge of their business. Convert this into a monthly retainer:

- Service: monthly 'AI check-in' — review new tools, update existing automations, identify new quick wins as the business evolves
- Price: $500–$1,500/month depending on engagement depth
- Revenue: 20 clients on retainer at $750/month = $15,000/month in recurring revenue
- The stickiness: the more you know about a client's specific business, tools, and processes, the harder it is for them to replace you
- This transforms the assessment from a one-time transaction into the beginning of an ongoing consulting relationship

Adjacent 5: Vertical-Specific AI Assessment Products

Rather than doing general AI assessments for all business types, specialize in one vertical and dominate it:

- Examples: 'AI Assessment for Real Estate Agents,' 'AI Audit for Wedding Venues,' 'AI Operations Review for Business Brokers'
- Advantage: you build industry-specific question banks, tool recommendations, and upsell packages that are pre-validated for that vertical
- Marketing: join the relevant industry associations; speak at industry conferences; write for industry publications
- Pricing premium: a specialist charges $2,000–$5,000 for what a generalist charges $1,000 for
- The reference path: Corey stumbled into wedding venues and business brokerages — and those became his best case studies. Intentionally specializing in one vertical accelerates this effect

The 30-Day Launch Plan: Zero to First Paying Client

This plan is designed for someone who is starting today with no AI consulting experience, no client base, and a willingness to spend 7–14 days learning the fundamentals before beginning outreach.

Week 1: Build Your Foundation (Days 1–7)

8. Day 1–2: Learn the essential tools. Spend 4–6 hours with Claude. Learn to prompt it effectively. Practice: paste a fake business description and ask it to identify AI opportunities and recommend specific tools. Get comfortable with the output.
9. Day 3: Study the AI tool landscape. Spend 2 hours on Futurepedia.io and Theresanaiforthat.com. Identify 20–30 tools across categories: meeting notetakers (Fathom, Fireflies), analytics (DashThis), CRM (GoHighLevel), automation (Zapier, Make.com), knowledge systems (custom GPTs), voice agents (Retell.ai).
10. Day 4: Watch Corey's Build with AI podcast on YouTube. Study his assessment process and upsell examples. Download the free template at audittemplate.ai and understand how the Gamma report works.
11. Day 5: Build your first practice assessment. Choose a fictional business (or a real one you know). Write out 10 questions you would ask. Paste them into Claude along with hypothetical answers. Ask Claude to generate an assessment report. Review and refine.
12. Day 6–7: Set up your tools. Create accounts on Gamma (gamma.app), Zapier (free tier), and optionally Retell.ai for a voice agent. Set up a simple booking link (Calendly) for assessment discovery calls.

Week 2: First Outreach and Free Assessments (Days 8–14)

13. Day 8: Identify 3 people in your existing professional network who run businesses. These are your first free assessment targets. Business owners with 5–50 employees and complex day-to-day operations are ideal.
14. Day 9: Reach out to all three. Message or call. Say: 'I have been spending time learning AI tools and how they apply to small businesses. I would love to do a free 45-minute AI assessment for your business — I'll send you a professional report showing exactly where AI can save you time and money. Zero cost, zero obligation. Want to try it?'
15. Day 10–12: Conduct your first free assessments over Zoom. Interview each owner using the question framework. Record the call. Take notes on their biggest pain points. After each call, paste the notes or transcript into Claude and generate the report draft. Format in Gamma.
16. Day 13: Deliver the first report to your first free client. Schedule a 30-minute follow-up call to walk through it. Pay close attention to their reaction to each recommendation — this tells you what resonates.
17. Day 14: Follow-up calls for all three free assessments. At the end of each: 'I noticed [specific pain point] could benefit from a more involved solution. I can build [specific

automation/custom GPT/agent] for you for $[price]. Want to explore that?' Even one yes at this stage validates the entire model.

Week 3: First Paid Assessment and Client Acquisition (Days 15–21)

18. Day 15: Set up your LinkedIn profile if not already active. Write one post about what you learned from your free assessment experience. Be specific and honest. This is the beginning of your content presence.
19. Day 16: Identify a local professional office (real estate office, insurance agency, accounting firm) and propose an AI office hours session. You show up once or twice a month; answer anyone's AI questions; no pitch. Your goal is contacts and leads.
20. Day 17–18: Start charging. Your first paid assessment should be at $200–$500 as you are still refining your process. Do not start at $1,000 until you have delivered five to ten assessments. Reach out to warm contacts and charge the assessment fee.
21. Day 19–20: Research local CEO groups, peer networks, or professional associations you could join or present at. Apply to speak at one. Prepare a 20-minute 'AI for Small Business' presentation — pure value, no pitch.
22. Day 21: Reflect and document. What questions worked best in your assessments? What tools got the most excited reactions? What upsell opportunities came up most often? Update your question bank and tool recommendations based on real data.

Week 4: Scale and Systematize (Days 22–30)

23. Day 22–24: Build your first Retell.ai voice agent if you are technically inclined. Otherwise, continue doing Zoom intake calls. The voice agent can come later — the business works without it.
24. Day 25: Raise your price to $500 if you started at $200. Raise to $1,000 once you have 10 completed assessments and at least 3 testimonials.
25. Day 26–28: Systematize the follow-up process. Every assessment should end with a booking link for the follow-up call. Every follow-up call should end with a clear upsell proposal or a 'not now' categorization. Build a simple CRM (a spreadsheet is fine at this stage) to track every prospect.
26. Day 29–30: Pick your first upsell specialty. Based on your first 10 assessments, which upsell came up most often? Custom GPT? Zapier automation? Speed-to-lead agent? Get very good at that one thing. This is how you productize the upsell and increase your effective hourly rate.

Revenue Projection: First 6 Months

Month	Assessments	Revenue/Assessment	Upsell Revenue	Monthly Total	Cumulative
Month 1	3 (free)	$0	$0 (but testimonials)	$0	$0
Month 2	4 ($200–$500 each)	$350 avg	$1,500 (one $1,500 Zapier build)	$2,900	$2,900
Month 3	6 ($500–$1,000 each)	$700 avg	$3,000 (two $1,500 builds)	$7,200	$10,100
Month 4	8 ($1,000 each)	$1,000	$6,000 (two $3,000 upsells)	$14,000	$24,100
Month 5	8–10 ($1,000 each)	$1,000	$8,000 (mix of upsells)	$17,000	$41,100
Month 6	10 ($1,000 each)	$1,000	$10,000 (retainer growth)	$20,000	$61,100

Closing Thoughts: The Gap Is Real and Wide Open

The AI adoption gap in small business is not a temporary condition. It is a structural reality: AI capabilities are advancing faster than most business owners can track or implement them. The consultant who sits between the AI tools and the business owner — translating capabilities into practical solutions for specific pain points — is one of the most valuable people a small business can work with in 2026.

Corey built his entire business on a single lunch conversation. His friend's willingness to pay $1,000 for someone to follow him around and identify AI opportunities was the signal. The product that emerged — the structured AI assessment — is repeatable, scalable, and now almost fully automated. A voice agent conducts the interview. Claude builds the report. Gamma formats the document. Corey shows up for the follow-up call and the upsell conversation.

The service sells because it solves a real, universal problem. Every business owner knows they should be using AI better. Almost none of them know how to start. The assessment gives them

a specific, personalized, actionable answer — not a generic blog post, not a generic tool recommendation, but a documented plan built around their specific workflow, their specific pain points, and their specific team.

You do not need to be an AI expert. You need to be one step ahead. Seven days of learning AI tools — actually using them, understanding what they do, seeing how they connect to real business problems — is enough to start. The market will not wait for you to feel ready. In 2 to 3 years, this category will be crowded. Today, it is wide open.

> *"You just need to be one step ahead of your average client, which is literally you studying this stuff for like 7 days and then you can easily go out and sell it. I did exactly that." — Corey Ganim*